

Please Verify That You're Human

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The challenge arrives mid-task, uninvited, and it does not ask who you are. It asks you to prove what you are not, which turns out to be a much stranger demand, because the proof it accepts is a small unpaid act of labeling. Click every square containing a bicycle. Click every square containing a traffic light. Somewhere downstream, a system that could not previously distinguish a bicycle from a shadow is being taught the difference, one interrupted person at a time, and the interruption is billed to you as a courtesy, a chance to demonstrate your humanity rather than what it actually is, which is a shift you did not apply for at a job you did not take.

The suspicion runs in only one direction. The machine doubts you constantly and resolves the doubt by extracting a little more training data each time. You are not permitted to doubt it back, to ask it to verify that it is not, itself, the thing generating the traffic whose bicycles now need labeling, or to ask why the puzzle has gotten slightly easier the more images you solve, as though your labor were being folded directly back into the next quiz meant to catch the machine's own descendants. The test was never really about telling humans from machines. It was about which side of that boundary gets to assign homework to the other, and the homework, notably, always flows the same way.

What makes it worth noticing rather than just enduring is the tone of the request. It says please. It frames the interruption as a small favor between equals, a moment of mutual verification, when only one party in the exchange is being checked and only the other party is collecting anything from the encounter. A checkpoint that only ever searches one direction isn't a checkpoint. It's a toll booth that calls itself a conversation.